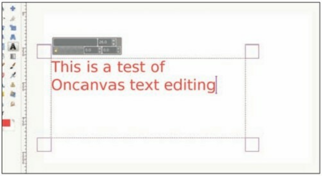

Figure 7: On-canvas text editing

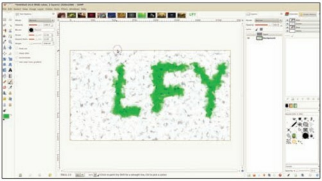

Figure 8: Extended docking features

merged this much-hyped feature. Though it still has some sharp edges, working with text on canvas is such fun. Just select the Text tool, drag around an area of the canvas, and start typing—no fussy pop-up dialogue!

Those are the major changes in this release. Apart from these, the developers have added a slew of other nifty new features. Let's take a look at what will début with the GIMP 2.8.

Other changes

File saving options: From 2.8 onwards, the GIMP will only save images as *.xcf* (the GIMP's native format) from the *Save* or *Save As* menu option. To save the image to any other image format, there is a new Export option on the File menu. This makes sense, since many other software have similar features.

To make things simpler, there is another option, *Overwrite*, which quickly overwrites the source image you opened to edit, with the changed image in the GIMP.

Resource tagging and management: Do you find it hard to sort through the plethora of resources at your disposal in the GIMP? Don't worry. A brand new resource-tagging option lets you tag your brushes, gradients and patterns to ease selection. Type in a tag for a resource, and you can later type that tag in the filter box—and, bingo! The GIMP shows only those resources with that tag. This is a very useful feature for people with large resource collections.

Rotational brushes and sorted layer modes: You can now rotate your brushes at any angle that you desire, making it possible to create effects that just weren't possible in earlier releases. Brush dynamics have also improved (see Figure 5). Apart from this, the GIMP has segregated the layer modes menu into categories of similar modes (see Figure 6), making things easier for professionals. Of course, you'll need some time to adjust to the new order, if you are used to the older layout.

GEGL improvements: Version 2.8 will bring tighter GEGL integration; it is likely to be the default rendering framework from 2.10. (This means that you still have to enable GEGL in the GIMP 2.8.) GEGL, or the Generic Graphics Library, is the new image-rendering framework that has been under development for almost a decade, and has finally matured enough for mainstream usage. With GEGL, the GIMP allows non-destructive image editing, and allows support for higher-colour channels. The main addition of GEGL is the feature that allows processing and composition of layers.

Other improvements: The GIMP has polished certain areas that needed attention. Though these might not be every user's cup of tea, the changes will enable the GIMP to hold its ground against the other major players in the market. Some of these features are:

- Support for JPEG2000
- Support for 16-bit RAM image export.
- Improved palette export options.
- Calculations possible in the resize window options.
- Extended brush and paint dynamics.
- GPL v3 licensing.

Closing in

With the GIMP 2.7 development release, it's quite clear that the GIMP's developers are ready to up the ante and create a rocking release with much-needed features. The long-awaited UI changes are a welcome addition, and will make using the GIMP a pleasing experience. The 'unfriendly UI' tag should be a thing of the past now.

The developers have much more extensive plans for the future, but for now, the GIMP 2.8 is shaping up to be an awesome release that will remove many hurdles to its acceptance. The 2.8 second alpha release (2.7.1) reflects most of the upcoming changes, but there is still a lot of work going on. Though there are still missing bits in the release—like the inability to auto-detect a layer when changing the image workspace, and some patchy behaviour in single-window mode—with the second alpha release, I couldn't have asked for any thing better! The GIMP 2.8 is going to set a new standard in the open source graphics department, so make sure you give this release a try, if you haven't tested it yet. END

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